TRW Automotive
Occupant Safety Systems

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Via Fax; Original by Certified Mail

June 15, 2001

Mr. Kenneth Weinstein
Associate Administrator for Safety Assurance
National Highway Traffic Safety Administration
400 Seventh Street, S.W.
Washington, D.C. 20590

Dear Mr. Weinstein,

Pursuant to Part 573 of Title 49 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Defect and Noncompliance Reports, TRW Vehicle Safety Systems Inc. ("VSSI") is submitting the following information concerning a potential defect in original equipment that may be related to motor vehicle safety.

573.5(c)(1) and (2)

The suspect equipment consists of certain seat belt buckle assemblies manufactured on behalf of VSSI, 4505 West 26 Mile Road, Washington, MI 48094, telephone number (810) 781-7200, at production plants in Del Norte and Reynosa, Mexico, for Ford Motor Company ("Ford") 2001 model year Crown Victoria, Grand Marquis, Town Car, Windstar, Ranger, F-Series (150, 250, 350), Excursion, Expedition, Navigator and Mazda B series truck platforms in which in certain circumstances the seat belt tongue may not latch properly or may become delatched if only partially latched. The specific VSSI buckle type is designated as the RNS4-G.

573.5(c)(3) and (4)

Only model year 2001 vehicles for the Ford platforms noted above have this specific buckle design, and only the driver and front outboard passenger position on those platforms are affected. The number of vehicles believed to be affected is approximately 1.5 million, although it is unknown at this time how many seat belt assemblies in those vehicles actually contain the potential defect. VSSI is conducting an investigation to determine the quantities and build dates involved. VSSI believes that less than two percent of the RNS4-G buckles at issue may be defective.

573.5(c)(5)

VSSI believes that RNS4-G buckles will fully and properly latch when the tongue is inserted firmly into the buckle. When latched, those buckles perform as intended. However, if the owner does not use reasonable and ordinary force to insert the tongue into the buckle, he or she may be able to induce the partial latched or

unlatched conditions. If partially latched, the buckles may not stay latched. If not fully latched, the buckles can be properly latched by firmly inserting the tongue into the buckle.

573.5(c)(6) and (7)

On April 5, 2001, VSSI was informed by Ford of a suspect buckle returned to Ford through its warranty program for Ford Ranger vehicles. VSSI began an investigation at that time. From May 2, 2001 through May 18, 2001, an additional five parts with the same concern, one of which had been located through Ford's warranty program and four of which were located through Ford plant inspections, were returned to VSSI. In addition, seven other RNS4-G buckles were returned to VSSI through the Ford warranty system on June 8, 2001. Analysis of these returned parts is not complete; however, all of these parts latch properly when the tongue is firmly inserted into the buckle in the ordinary manner.

573.5(c)(8), (10) and (11)

VSSI is implementing permanent design and production process changes to address the root cause of the potential defect. Additional inspections have been added to the production process to ensure that all current product does not have the potential defect.

Because all seat belt units that may have the potential defect work properly when used in ordinary manner, VSSI has not yet determined the proper remedy for this potential defect. VSSI, in cooperation with Ford, is working diligently to make this determination.

Very truly yours,

O.S.B.

Gary Flattery
Vice President, Quality

TRW Vehicle Safety Systems Inc.

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